

something or someone to blame for it. First, I tried to blame the system. The worse you've done, the more you're convinced that Wall Street is rigged and the cards are stacked against you. After what I'd seen of analysts with no time to analyze, portfolio managers who couldn't beat the averages, and especially stockbrokers practicing their dialogues, I was prepared to distrust everyone.

Then I remembered that half the country was making money on Wall Street. It's ridiculous to blame the system in a bull market.

Next, I tried blaming the broker. How, I wondered, could Ms. Garrett have lured me into Angstrom on the word of some idiot from Philadelphia? How could she have kept up the storytelling, the optimism, the cheery projections? How could I have picked such a silly broker in the first place?

Before I got far with this, I remembered I'd had too many other brokers to continue this infantile lament. Let's face it. Linda Garrett didn't make me buy Angstrom. I insisted on buying it myself. In my experience, the major complaint against brokers, that they pressure customers and "churn" the accounts to get more commissions, is unfounded. I've always churned my own accounts without any encouragement. It's me who always calls the broker, wondering why something hasn't moved, or suggesting we switch into something more profitable.

Gillette was Ms. Garrett's suggestion, but again I called her. After the first few weeks, I always called her and she never called me. If anything, the broker is likely to wait for the client to commit himself, as opposed to the churning for which they're unjustly accused.

Think of it from the broker's point of view. If he's smart, he'll always agree with what the client proposes instead of pushing his own recommendations. If the client turns out to be right, then the broker looks good as well. If the client turns out to be wrong, the broker can always say, "That one was your idea."

Why was I unable to see my broker as the salesperson I knew her to be? After all, I'd been to broker's school, yet I still held on to the fiction that Ms. Garrett was the expert, and a parental figure who could be blamed for my results. I didn't expect a shoe salesman to know anything about podiatry, so why should I expect the broker to know anything about finance? The whole broker-